ACC
PREVENTION. CARE. RECOVERY.
Te Kaporeihana Āwhina Hunga Whara

Caring for your... Plaster Cast

A CAST is often used to surround and protect an injured limb so that it can heal

If you look after your cast, you'll heal much quicker

The first 2-3 days

Plaster casts are made of a chalky white substance that sets hard after about 48 hours. While the cast is drying try not to:

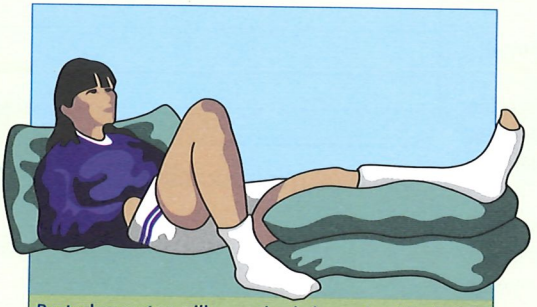
- rest it on anything hard or press down on it
- expose it to heat e.g. hair dryers, fires, electric blankets
- get it wet

Initially the cast may feel snug or tight due to swelling. Keep the cast raised as much as possible. Wiggling your fingers/toes and regular movement of the nearby joints can help.

Paracetamol can help ease pain. Ask your doctor or pharmacist for advice about pain medication.



Slings help raise arm casts. The fingers of the arm with the cast should touch the opposite shoulder



Rest a leg cast on pillows raised above shoulder height

If you have any worries about your plaster cast, contact the clinic where it was applied, your general practitioner or nearest Accident & Medical centre

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Discomfort If the cast is rubbing or pinching, contact your health care provider. Do not:

- remove or change the cast yourself e.g. cut or try to trim the edges
- pull out the padding; it protects your skin
- place additional padding inside the cast

Baths & showers You need to keep your cast as dry as possible. Not only will a wet cast become soft, but water can get inside and irritate or damage your skin. If the cast gets wet, it may need to be replaced. Contact your health care provider for advice. With an arm or below-the-knee plaster cast when washing (or around water), wrap a dry towel around the cast and cover it with a plastic bag. Use waterproof tape to tape the bag firmly to the skin around the cast and keep away from the water. If you have an above-the-knee cast use a face cloth to wash.

Mild itchiness Try gently tapping the cast over the area or using a hair dryer blowing 'cool' air. If the skin under and around the cast is itchy all over, call your health care provider for advice. Try not to:

- poke objects down the cast, this may damage the skin and cause infection
- put lotions, creams, oils, or powders inside or around the edges of the cast

Activity This depends on your injury. It is important to follow your health care provider's instructions. If you are unsure what is safe, seek advice. Try not to:

- lift heavy objects or 'work' the injured limb (e.g. play sports)
- walk with a leg cast without using crutches or a special plaster boot
- use a sling longer than told to

Cast fit and damage After a while the cast may not fit well, contact your health care provider if it feels too loose or tight. If it softens, breaks or cracks, contact the clinic where it was applied.

Seek Help Immediately seek help if you feel any of the following:

- fingers and toes: burning or severe pain despite keeping the cast raised and taking pain medication, persistent numbness or tingling, loss of movement, discoloration e.g. white, blue or red/purple
- the injured limb: increased swelling, becoming very hot or cold, a feeling that you have a blister or sore inside your cast, ooze from a wound in the cast or any unusual or foul smell
- if you develop a fever

Removal When your injury has healed special scissors or a vibrating saw that does not harm the skin will be used to remove the cast.

Personal instructions

Your cast will need to stay on for about:

Important phone numbers

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